

## Mount Stewart House

## March



**Mount Stewart House:** a lovely old march; it fits in well with many other small 2/4s and deserves to be better known. It was published first in *Uilleam Ross's Collection*, and later in Logan and Glen. I have only ever known the tune under this title, but it appears in Colin Cameron's manuscript as "Lewie Gordon, Quickstep By W. Mackay".

The tune was written to commemorate the original early 18<sup>th</sup> century house on the eastern side of the Isle of Bute which was so badly damaged by fire in 1877 that it was replaced by a sumptuous new design commissioned by the 3<sup>rd</sup> marquess of Bute in a fantastically ornate Gothic style. At the time of his death in 1900 it was still under construction and remains incomplete.

As the seat of the coal-rich Crichton-Stuart family it was the first dwelling house in Scotland to have electric lighting and a heated swimming pool. It also boasted an extraordinary "Horoscope Room", whose ceiling took the form of an astrological chart giving the precise position of the planets at the time of the birth of the 3<sup>rd</sup> marquess on 12<sup>th</sup> September 1847. It is currently the bedroom of the present holder of the title sporting a "magnificent bed...with carvings...inspired by the mediaeval tale of Reynard the Fox...playing a Psaltery to lull Noble the lion to sleep. Opposite, Grimbarde the Badger clutches a set of bagpipes with which to awaken Noble from his slumbers." (*Mount Stuart*, official guidebook, 2001, p.27).